2.5

Battalion Command: Iron Fist in a Velvet Glove

In the summer of 2000, I had just been posted as the GSO 1 (Training) to the Sikh Light Infantry Training Centre at Fatehgarh, Uttar Pradesh. Fatehgarh is a mofussil town halfway between Agra and Kanpur, which the world seems to have given a go-by. I had been posted there earlier in the late 1980s as the Adjutant of the Training Centre and nothing much seemed to have changed in the intervening two decades.

My daily routine was to go around the training areas in the early hours of the day, before it got too hot, supervise the day's activities and then retreat to the relatively cooler climes of the office to do the routine paperwork. I say relatively, because we did not even have the luxury of air conditioners back then. One morning, barely a week after I had assumed charge, I was at the short-range both supervising and doing some firing myself, when the office runner came frantically in search of me saying that I had an urgent call from the Colonel of the Regiment. The COR then was Maj Gen Ashok Kapur, and I had been his

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